

Reflection

Monster of the Week — Session 2 Facilitation

GAME2102 · Bow Valley College · Feb 2026 · Instructor: Yash | Session Keeper: Michael

How the Session Compared to the Plan

Going into this session, I had a somewhat clear trajectory in mind for the story. The goal was never to railroad anyone, but to have enough structure that I could stay oriented while the players made their own decisions. In practice, the session followed that backbone reasonably well, but the texture of it shifted considerably from what I had prepared.

The most notable divergence was the two bystander characters I had prepared: Marty, a hippie living in a treehouse who had witnessed the ghoul's movements, and Tyrell, a man with terminal cancer and a complicated motivation involving life insurance. I had imagined them being encountered naturally and casually along the way. What actually happened was, that just didn't work out. Neither character appeared; oh well. In hindsight, I had underestimated how much bandwidth new and inexperienced players need just to navigate the mechanics, let alone engage with optional story content.

Key Player Choices That Shaped the Narrative

Several player decisions had a significant impact on how the session unfolded. Viper's choice to cut the sigil from the ghoul's hands was unexpected, but a great idea. It gave Eilian something physical to investigate, which led to the discovery of the ghoul's long-distance communication spell. That detail added a layer of urgency and paranoia that I thought landed well.

The encounter with Xanthan at the abandoned general store was another moment where player engagement shaped the outcome. After trying to neutralize him (Much to Eilian's delight), the group leaned into the mechanic of winning him over, which paid off. It was a small moment, but it shifted the tone from combat-focused to something more creative.

What Worked

Coming in with a prepared trajectory but deliberately leaving room for deviation worked better than I expected. Having the countdown as a structural backbone meant I always had a sense of where things were heading, even when the players went in an unexpected direction. It functioned less like a script and more like those things that stop cars from flying off of cliffs.

Making things up on the fly was more engaging than I anticipated. There is a particular kind of focus that comes from having to respond to what players do in real time, and I found that exercise genuinely enjoyable. Having pre-built characters and locations to draw from made improvisation easier.

Challenges and How They Were Addressed

The biggest challenge was balancing pacing against the group's need to talk through decisions. Two of the four players had no prior exposure to tabletop roleplaying, which meant that mechanical questions came up frequently and mid-scene. Maintaining narrative momentum was ... shall we say, difficult, in some moments. I'd rather attempt to herd coked-out rats, at least you can grab them by the scruff of their neck.

The dice, oh my gods, the dice were their own player characters. I had played TTRPGs before, but only digitally, with automated rollers. I know that physical dice can be evil, but whoof, there were some abysmal rolls in this campaign.

Lessons Learned

The experience reinforced something I had suspected but not fully understood before running a session: player agency is not just a design principle, it is the actual engine of the game. The moments that felt most alive were the ones where the players did something I hadn't anticipated and I had to respond. Trying to over-plan for those moments would have killed them.

I also came away with a clearer appreciation for the rotating Keeper format. Having all players eventually take on the facilitation role changes the relationship to the story. It is a structure I had never encountered before this course, and one I think rotating the DM every session produces a more chaotic/shitposty than I expected. It was fun, but I'd prefer to rotate DM per arc, not per-session.

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